Common Diseases Explained

Plain-language reference for patients

Important: This guide explains common conditions in simple words, compiled from standard public health guidance (for example WHO, CDC, NHS and MedlinePlus). It does not diagnose and does not replace a doctor. Treatment decisions, especially prescription medicines, must come from a qualified doctor. Review by a clinician is recommended before real use.

Index

Condition	Type	Who to see
Type 2 diabetes	Long-term condition	Endocrinology or diabetologist; start with a general physician.
High blood pressure (hypertension)	Long-term condition	General physician or Cardiology.
Asthma	Long-term condition	Pulmonology or a general physician.
Dengue	Infection (mosquito-borne)	General physician or Internal medicine; emergency care for warning signs.
Malaria	Infection (mosquito-borne)	General physician or Internal medicine.
Typhoid fever	Infection (food and water)	General physician or Internal medicine.
Tuberculosis (TB)	Infection (airborne)	Pulmonology or Chest physician.
Influenza (flu)	Infection (airborne)	General physician.
Pneumonia	Infection (lungs)	Pulmonology or General physician.
Anemia (iron deficiency)	Blood condition	General physician or Hematology.
Urinary tract infection (UTI)	Infection	General physician, Urology or Gynecology.
Migraine	Neurological condition	Neurology.
Hepatitis A (jaundice)	Infection (food and water)	Gastroenterology or Hepatology.
Chickenpox	Infection (airborne)	General physician or Pediatrics.
Gastroenteritis (stomach infection, food poisoning)	Infection (food and water)	Gastroenterology or General physician.
Hypothyroidism	Hormone condition	Endocrinology.
Depression	Mental health condition	Psychiatry or Psychology.
Osteoarthritis	Joint condition	Orthopedics or Rheumatology.
Allergic rhinitis (hay fever)	Allergy	ENT specialist or Allergy specialist.
Heart attack warning signs	Emergency	Cardiology (via emergency department).
Stroke warning signs	Emergency	Neurology (via emergency department).

Type 2 diabetes (Long-term condition)

What it is	Type 2 diabetes: A condition where the body cannot use insulin well, so blood sugar stays high.
Common symptoms	Increased thirst, frequent urination, tiredness, blurred vision, slow-healing wounds, frequent infections. Early on there may be no symptoms.
Cause / spread	Linked to excess weight, inactivity, family history and age. It is not caught from other people.
Prevention	Healthy weight, regular exercise, less sugary food and refined carbohydrates, no tobacco, regular check-ups if at risk.
General care	Diagnosed by blood tests (fasting glucose, HbA1c). Management is diet, exercise, weight control and medicines or insulin decided by a doctor. Regular eye, kidney and foot checks are needed.
When to get help	See a doctor for the symptoms above. Emergency: vomiting, confusion, fruity-smelling breath, drowsiness or very high sugar readings.
Who to see	Endocrinology or diabetologist; start with a general physician.

High blood pressure (hypertension) (Long-term condition)

What it is	High blood pressure (hypertension): Blood pressure that stays too high and strains the heart and blood vessels. It often has no symptoms.
Common symptoms	Usually none. Very high pressure can cause severe headache, chest pain, blurred vision or breathlessness.
Cause / spread	Too much salt, excess weight, inactivity, alcohol, stress, family history, age.
Prevention	Less salt, healthy weight, regular exercise, limit alcohol, no tobacco, regular blood pressure checks.
General care	Confirmed by repeated measurements. Lifestyle changes and medicines prescribed by a doctor. Do not stop medicines without medical advice.
When to get help	See a doctor if readings are repeatedly 140/90 or higher. Emergency: very high pressure with chest pain, severe headache, vision change, weakness or confusion.
Who to see	General physician or Cardiology.

Asthma (Long-term condition)

What it is	Asthma: A lung condition where the airways become inflamed and narrow, making breathing difficult.
Common symptoms	Wheezing, cough (often at night or early morning), chest tightness, shortness of breath.
Cause / spread	Triggers include dust, pollen, smoke, cold air, exercise, infections and strong smells. Often runs in families.
Prevention	Avoid known triggers, avoid smoking and smoke, keep the home clean and dry, follow the doctor's asthma plan.
General care	Doctor-prescribed reliever and controller inhalers and a written action plan. Carry the reliever inhaler.
When to get help	See a doctor for repeated wheeze or night cough. Emergency: cannot speak full sentences, blue lips, or the reliever inhaler does not help.
Who to see	Pulmonology or a general physician.

Dengue (Infection (mosquito-borne))

What it is	Dengue: A viral infection spread by Aedes mosquitoes that bite mostly during the day.
Common symptoms	Sudden high fever, severe headache, pain behind the eyes, muscle and joint pain, rash, nausea.
Cause / spread	Spread by the bite of an infected mosquito, not directly from person to person. Common in rainy seasons.
Prevention	Remove standing water, use repellent, wear long sleeves, use mosquito nets and screens.
General care	Rest and plenty of fluids. Paracetamol can be used for fever. Do NOT take aspirin or ibuprofen because they can increase bleeding risk. A doctor may order blood tests to monitor platelets.
When to get help	See a doctor early if you have fever in a dengue area. Emergency warning signs (often 3 to 7 days after fever starts): severe stomach pain, repeated vomiting, bleeding gums or nose, blood in vomit or stool, extreme weakness or restlessness.
Who to see	General physician or Internal medicine; emergency care for warning signs.

Malaria (Infection (mosquito-borne))

What it is	Malaria: A parasite infection spread by Anopheles mosquitoes, which bite mostly at night.
Common symptoms	Fever with chills and heavy sweating that may come in cycles, headache, body aches, tiredness, nausea.
Cause / spread	Spread by the bite of an infected mosquito. It does not spread by touch or coughing.
Prevention	Sleep under treated mosquito nets, use repellent, remove stagnant water, take preventive medicine when advised for travel.
General care	Needs a blood test for diagnosis. Treatment uses antimalarial medicines chosen by a doctor, and the full course must be completed.
When to get help	See a doctor the same day for fever in a malaria area. Emergency: confusion, seizures, trouble breathing, very pale or yellow skin, or passing very little urine.
Who to see	General physician or Internal medicine.

Typhoid fever (Infection (food and water))

What it is	Typhoid fever: A bacterial infection (Salmonella Typhi) spread through contaminated food and water.
Common symptoms	Fever that rises over several days, weakness, stomach pain, headache, loss of appetite, constipation or diarrhea.
Cause / spread	Eating or drinking food or water contaminated with infected faeces.
Prevention	Drink safe boiled or treated water, wash hands with soap, eat well-cooked food, typhoid vaccination where advised.
General care	Diagnosed with blood tests. Antibiotics are prescribed by a doctor. Rest and fluids at home.
When to get help	See a doctor if fever lasts more than 3 days. Emergency: severe stomach pain, blood in stool, confusion or persistent vomiting.
Who to see	General physician or Internal medicine.

Tuberculosis (TB) (Infection (airborne))

What it is	Tuberculosis (TB): A bacterial infection that mainly affects the lungs and spreads through the air.
Common symptoms	Cough lasting more than 2 to 3 weeks, coughing blood, fever, night sweats, weight loss, tiredness.
Cause / spread	Spreads when a person with lung TB coughs or sneezes. Close contacts are at higher risk.
Prevention	Complete treatment, cover the mouth when coughing, good ventilation, BCG vaccine in children, screen close contacts.
General care	TB is curable. Treatment is a combination of medicines, usually for at least 6 months, and must never be stopped early. Free treatment is available through national TB programmes in many countries.
When to get help	See a doctor for a cough lasting more than 2 weeks, especially with weight loss or night sweats. Emergency: coughing blood or severe breathlessness.
Who to see	Pulmonology or Chest physician.

Influenza (flu) (Infection (airborne))

What it is	Influenza (flu): A viral infection of the nose, throat and lungs that spreads easily.
Common symptoms	Sudden fever, body aches, tiredness, cough, sore throat, runny nose.
Cause / spread	Spread through droplets when infected people cough or sneeze, and by touching contaminated surfaces.
Prevention	Yearly flu vaccine, hand washing, cover coughs, stay home when sick.
General care	Rest, fluids, and paracetamol for fever and aches. Most people recover in about a week.
When to get help	See a doctor early if you are elderly, pregnant, have a long-term illness, or symptoms are severe. Emergency: trouble breathing, chest pain, confusion.
Who to see	General physician.

Pneumonia (Infection (lungs))

What it is	Pneumonia: An infection that inflames the air sacs in the lungs, caused by bacteria, viruses or other germs.
Common symptoms	Cough with phlegm, fever, fast or difficult breathing, chest pain when breathing or coughing, tiredness.
Cause / spread	Spreads like other chest infections through droplets. Risk is higher in babies, elderly people and smokers.
Prevention	Vaccines (pneumococcal, flu), no smoking, hand washing, treat colds early.
General care	Needs a doctor's assessment. Treatment depends on the cause and may include antibiotics prescribed by a doctor.
When to get help	See a doctor the same day for cough with fever and fast breathing. Emergency: severe breathlessness, blue lips, confusion.
Who to see	Pulmonology or General physician.

Anemia (iron deficiency) (Blood condition)

What it is	Anemia (iron deficiency): A condition where the blood has too little hemoglobin to carry oxygen.
Common symptoms	Tiredness, pale skin, dizziness, shortness of breath on effort, fast heartbeat, headache.
Cause / spread	Low iron in the diet, blood loss (heavy periods, ulcers), pregnancy, low vitamin B12 or folate.
Prevention	Eat iron-rich foods (leafy greens, lentils, beans, meat, eggs) with vitamin C foods, treat worms, follow pregnancy care advice.
General care	Diagnosed with a blood test. Iron or vitamin supplements are best started after testing and with a doctor's advice. The cause of the anemia must be found.
When to get help	See a doctor for ongoing tiredness or paleness. Emergency: fainting, chest pain, severe breathlessness.
Who to see	General physician or Hematology.

Urinary tract infection (UTI) (Infection)

What it is	Urinary tract infection (UTI): An infection of the bladder or urinary tract, more common in women.
Common symptoms	Burning when passing urine, frequent urge to urinate, lower belly pain, cloudy or strong-smelling urine.
Cause / spread	Bacteria from the bowel reaching the urinary tract.
Prevention	Drink plenty of water, do not hold urine, wipe front to back, pass urine after sex.
General care	Needs a urine test. Antibiotics are prescribed by a doctor. Drink plenty of fluids.
When to get help	See a doctor the same day. Urgent: fever, back or side pain, vomiting, blood in urine, or if pregnant.
Who to see	General physician, Urology or Gynecology.

Migraine (Neurological condition)

What it is	Migraine: A recurring headache disorder, often one-sided and throbbing.
Common symptoms	Throbbing headache, nausea, sensitivity to light and sound, sometimes visual changes (aura) beforehand.
Cause / spread	Triggers include stress, missed meals, poor sleep, hormonal changes, certain foods, bright light.
Prevention	Regular sleep and meals, manage stress, keep a trigger diary, stay hydrated.
General care	Rest in a dark quiet room. Pain relievers from the medicine guide may help early. Frequent attacks need preventive treatment from a doctor.
When to get help	See a doctor for frequent or worsening headaches. Emergency: sudden worst headache, weakness, speech trouble, stiff neck with fever.
Who to see	Neurology.

Hepatitis A (jaundice) (Infection (food and water))

What it is	Hepatitis A (jaundice): A viral liver infection spread through contaminated food and water. Usually recovers without lasting damage.
Common symptoms	Yellow skin and eyes, dark urine, pale stools, tiredness, nausea, loss of appetite, stomach pain.
Cause / spread	Eating food or drinking water contaminated with infected faeces.
Prevention	Safe water, hand washing, good sanitation, hepatitis A vaccine.
General care	Rest, fluids, light food. Avoid alcohol and ask a doctor before taking any medicines.
When to get help	See a doctor for yellow eyes or skin. Emergency: confusion, drowsiness, persistent vomiting, bleeding.
Who to see	Gastroenterology or Hepatology.

Chickenpox (Infection (airborne))

What it is	Chickenpox: A viral infection that causes an itchy blistering rash. It spreads very easily.
Common symptoms	Fever, tiredness, then itchy red spots that become fluid-filled blisters and crust over.
Cause / spread	Spreads through the air and by touching blister fluid. Infectious until all blisters have crusted.
Prevention	Chickenpox vaccine. Stay home until blisters have crusted.
General care	Rest, fluids, calamine lotion, keep nails short. Paracetamol for fever. Do not give aspirin to children.
When to get help	See a doctor if the person is pregnant, a newborn, has a weak immune system, blisters become red and infected, or the eye is involved.
Who to see	General physician or Pediatrics.

Gastroenteritis (stomach infection, food poisoning) (Infection (food and water))

What it is	Gastroenteritis (stomach infection, food poisoning): An infection of the stomach and intestines causing vomiting and diarrhea.
Common symptoms	Watery diarrhea, vomiting, stomach cramps, fever, tiredness.
Cause / spread	Contaminated food or water, or contact with an infected person.
Prevention	Hand washing, safe food storage, cook food well, drink safe water.
General care	Sip oral rehydration solution often, eat light food, rest.
When to get help	See a doctor if it lasts more than 3 days, there is blood in stool, high fever, or signs of dehydration (very dry mouth, little urine, dizziness).
Who to see	Gastroenterology or General physician.

Hypothyroidism (Hormone condition)

What it is	Hypothyroidism: A condition where the thyroid gland makes too little thyroid hormone.
Common symptoms	Tiredness, weight gain, feeling cold, constipation, dry skin, hair thinning, low mood, slow heartbeat.
Cause / spread	Often an autoimmune condition. Also caused by iodine problems or thyroid treatment.
Prevention	Adequate iodine in diet. Regular thyroid tests if you have a family history.
General care	Diagnosed by a blood test (TSH). Treatment is usually a daily thyroid hormone tablet prescribed by a doctor, often long term.
When to get help	See a doctor for the symptoms above. Emergency: extreme drowsiness, very low body temperature or confusion.
Who to see	Endocrinology.

Depression (Mental health condition)

What it is	Depression: A medical condition causing persistent low mood and loss of interest. It is common and treatable.
Common symptoms	Feeling sad or empty for 2 weeks or more, loss of interest, poor sleep or sleeping too much, appetite changes, tiredness, guilt, trouble concentrating.
Cause / spread	Caused by a mix of biology, life events, stress and family history. It is not a weakness.
Prevention	Stay connected with others, regular sleep and activity, early help for stress.
General care	Talking therapy, medicines and lifestyle support, as decided with a doctor. Talk to a trusted person.
When to get help	See a doctor if low mood lasts more than 2 weeks. If you have thoughts of harming yourself, seek emergency help or a crisis helpline immediately.
Who to see	Psychiatry or Psychology.

Osteoarthritis (Joint condition)

What it is	Osteoarthritis: Wear of the joint cartilage that causes pain and stiffness, most often in knees, hips and hands.
Common symptoms	Joint pain that worsens with use, stiffness after rest (usually under 30 minutes), swelling, reduced movement.
Cause / spread	Age, joint injury, excess weight and family history.
Prevention	Healthy weight, regular low-impact exercise, protect joints from injury.
General care	Exercise and physiotherapy, weight loss, heat packs. Pain relievers from the medicine guide may help. A doctor can advise on other treatment.
When to get help	See a doctor for persistent joint pain. Urgent: a hot, red, very swollen joint with fever.
Who to see	Orthopedics or Rheumatology.

Allergic rhinitis (hay fever) (Allergy)

What it is	Allergic rhinitis (hay fever): An allergy of the nose caused by dust, pollen or other triggers.
Common symptoms	Sneezing, runny or blocked nose, itchy eyes and throat, watery eyes.
Cause / spread	The immune system reacts to dust mites, pollen, pets or mould.
Prevention	Avoid triggers, keep windows closed in high pollen season, wash bedding often, saline nose rinse.
General care	Saline rinse and antihistamines from the medicine guide. A doctor may prescribe a nasal spray.
When to get help	See a doctor if symptoms last more than 7 days, affect sleep, or come with wheezing.
Who to see	ENT specialist or Allergy specialist.

Heart attack warning signs (Emergency)

What it is	Heart attack warning signs: A heart attack happens when blood flow to the heart is blocked. It is a medical emergency.
Common symptoms	Chest pain, pressure or tightness, pain spreading to the arm, jaw or back, sweating, nausea, breathlessness, light-headedness.
Cause / spread	Usually caused by blocked heart arteries. Risk rises with high blood pressure, diabetes, smoking, high cholesterol.
Prevention	No smoking, healthy diet, exercise, control blood pressure, sugar and cholesterol.
General care	Do not wait. Call emergency services immediately and sit down and rest. Do not drive yourself. Follow the instructions of the emergency operator.
When to get help	EMERGENCY: call emergency services at once for any of these signs.
Who to see	Cardiology (via emergency department).

Stroke warning signs (Emergency)

What it is	Stroke warning signs: A stroke happens when blood flow to part of the brain is blocked or a vessel bleeds. It is a medical emergency.
Common symptoms	Use FAST: Face drooping, Arm weakness, Speech difficulty, Time to call emergency services. Also sudden vision loss, confusion, severe headache, loss of balance.
Cause / spread	Linked to high blood pressure, diabetes, smoking, heart rhythm problems and high cholesterol.
Prevention	Control blood pressure, no smoking, exercise, healthy diet, take prescribed medicines.
General care	Call emergency services immediately and note the time symptoms began. Do not give food, drink or medicines.
When to get help	EMERGENCY: call emergency services at once for any of these signs.
Who to see	Neurology (via emergency department).